

The problem of Fort Sumter

When Lincoln assumed office, Scott advised the president to abandon the Federal garrison stationed at Fort Sumter in order to avoid a direct military confrontation, but Lincoln's first loyalty remained with the Federal government. Scott obeyed Lincoln's orders to resupply the fort with provisions, despite Confederate threats to respond with force. Lincoln hoped to avoid bloodshed by initially using only announced and unarmed vessels carrying nonmilitary supplies, but he would not relinquish the post.

From the Confederate perspective, the very fact that Federal troops were manning a military installation in Charleston Harbor within the cradle of secession mocked the idea of Southern independence. The two sides were on a collision course, and the most important question would be how the upper South would respond to an outbreak of violence.